

for the teams you represent.

When you do get back, you remember all those days you missed because of the injury. That's where the motivation comes from.

You've batted in different positions for India. How difficult is that adjustment?

Moving down the order isn't as difficult as people make it out to be. When you open the batting, if you score a hundred or a big score, you usually bat through most of the innings anyway. So, you understand the different phases of the game.

The bigger challenge is when a middle-order batter suddenly has to open. Then you're facing the premium bowlers with the new ball from both ends. That's a much tougher adjustment.

You've spent years alongside M.S. Dhoni and are now the captain of the Chennai Super

Kings. What are the biggest leadership lessons you've learned from him?

One thing I've learnt from him is to keep things very simple.

Sometimes, as a responsible player in the team, you tend to overthink decisions. You think about all the ifs and buts. With him, I feel things are kept really simple. He lets the game flow and then arrives at a conclusion.

That simplicity is something he has carried throughout the years, and the results have backed that approach.

For me, it's about balancing that with my own thought process and understanding how I can help the team win. Results are essential for any team, so you try to get into that mindset and figure out how best you can contribute.

Leading a franchise like CSK brings a different level of scrutiny and expectation. What have the last two seasons taught you?

More than being the captain of CSK, I feel that even as a player, if you don't make the playoffs, you're disappointed. Every player who takes part in the IPL feels that way.

I've been through a journey with CSK where we finished runners-up, then didn't qualify, then won the IPL, then again didn't qualify, and then won it once more. So I've experienced success, but I've also seen the rock-bottom phases.

The last two years haven't gone the way everyone expected. But you also have to understand the dynamics and factors that affect a season. In 2025, me being captain and missing more than half the tournament was definitely a setback. Last year too, we had four or five players from our playing XI miss almost half the tournament.

Even if you look at successful teams like RCB, if you take away three or four key players, it's definitely going to have an impact.

Those are factors that a lot of people don't take into account. It's a results-driven tournament, and everyone expects CSK to do well every year because that's what the franchise has done for the last 15 or 16 seasons.

But there will always be phases when things don't go your way. You learn from them and try to improve. Compared to 2025, we had a much better season in 2026,

Back with a bang: Ruturaj shrugged off an average IPL to rediscover his rhythm in Sri Lanka, amassing 274 runs, including a sublime century, as India-A lifted the Tri-Nation Series title. PTI

